

Notes on Faculty Feedback

The proposed revision of the Spanish major responds to urgent structural, enrollment, and institutional realities. While change understandably invites debate, maintaining the status quo is no longer a sustainable option.

First, the major is long overdue for revision. It has been many years since we last undertook a comprehensive review of the undergraduate major. In that time, the field of Spanish studies, student expectations, and the institutional landscape for language programs have changed dramatically.

Second, declining enrollments demand immediate action. Spanish enrollments—like those of many language programs nationally—are significantly down. This has direct consequences for faculty teaching opportunities, graduate student funding and professionalization, and the overall vitality of the department. If we do not take steps to attract more majors and retain students, we risk further contraction and external intervention. The revised major is intentionally designed to lower barriers to entry, clarify degree pathways, and make the major legible and attractive to students early in their academic careers.

Third, this revision demonstrates proactivity and leadership. At a time when humanities and language programs face increased scrutiny, it is essential that we show the administration that we are responsive, innovative, and forward-looking. This proposal signals that the department is actively addressing enrollment challenges and modernizing its curriculum rather than reacting defensively or passively to decline.

Fourth, the proposed structure aligns with peer programs. The revised major is consistent with other Romance language departments at Rutgers and with Big Ten language departments more broadly, many of which have moved away from rigid track systems in favor of flexible, broadly grounded majors. These programs recognize that overspecialization at the undergraduate level often deters students, complicates advising, and delays time to degree.

Fifth, the revised major is more equitable and inclusive of faculty expertise. Rather than privileging one subfield or implying a hierarchy of “more” or “less” legitimate Spanish study, the new structure values the full range of faculty specializations—literature, linguistics, SLA, bilingualism, translation, cultural studies, and interdisciplinary work. It creates opportunities for all faculty to contribute meaningfully to the major and reflects the intellectual diversity of the department.

Finally, a rigid track system is inappropriate for a BA in Spanish. Students earn a Bachelor of Arts in Spanish, not a subdisciplinary credential. At this level, students need broad

preparation, flexibility, and exposure to multiple areas of study. Track systems often promise specialization that cannot realistically be delivered given course availability, and they restrict students' ability to progress efficiently toward the degree. The revised major avoids these pitfalls while maintaining academic rigor.

The revision responds to many Google Doc Comments:

1. Avoid rigid “tracks” while still signaling professional relevance

Issue raised: Tracks/pathways confuse students and limit flexibility, but “Interdisciplinary” is too vague and “Language Intensive” implies hierarchy.

2. Renaming suggestions

Issue raised: “Linguistics” is misleading and less appealing to students

Replace “Linguistics” in some places with Language, SLA, and Bilingualism.

Substitute “Interdisciplinary” with “Spanish for Communities and Professions”

3. Eliminate mandatory capstone language

Issue raised: Capstones reduce flexibility and may be unsustainable with enrollments

A capstone or 400-level course will not be required but it will be encouraged. We can revisit if enrollments grow.

4. De-emphasize “gateway” sequencing

Issue raised: Forcing early gateways complicates scheduling, yet students need the foundational courses

Reframe gateway courses as “**required core courses**” with flexible sequencing.

Also, explicitly state that **203/204 count toward the major**, so students see progress early.